WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

NETHERLANDS

Europe

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Amsterdam and Schiphol	Financial and commercial capital with Schiphol airport, home to many European headquarters and more than 3,000 international companies in the Amsterdam area	Financial services, technology, creative industries, headquarters functions
Rotterdam and the port industrial complex	The country's main seaport and a leading European gateway, handling 212.0 million tonnes in the first half of 2026, where the first section of the national hydrogen network has been activated	Logistics, energy and refining, chemicals, hydrogen and carbon capture
Eindhoven / Brainport region	Home of ASML and a world-leading semiconductor equipment cluster, supported by the €2.5 billion Project Beethoven package for talent, transport, housing and grid capacity	Semiconductors, photonics, high-tech systems, R&D
The Hague	Seat of government and parliament and of many international legal and security institutions	Government relations, legal services, security and defence technology
Utrecht and the central Netherlands	Central location on the national road and rail network with a large university and strong services base	Business services, IT, life sciences, logistics
North Sea coast and the northern provinces	Focus of offshore wind and the energy transition, with hydrogen network links planned towards Germany and Belgium	Offshore wind, hydrogen, energy infrastructure

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Netherlands Foreign Investment Agency (NFIA / Invest in Holland), which supported 180 foreign investment projects in 2025, with R&D the largest category for the first time
- Corporate income tax of 19% on profits up to €200,000 and 25.8% above, with an innovation box taxing qualifying intellectual-property profits at an effective 9%
- WBSO R&D credit reducing payroll tax by 36% of the first €391,020 of eligible R&D costs (50% for start-ups), administered by the Netherlands Enterprise Agency (RVO)
- Advance Tax Rulings and Advance Pricing Agreements giving up to five years of certainty, with a dedicated liaison for potential foreign investors
- The 30% ruling for qualifying skilled migrants, capped at €78,600 in 2026 and reducing to 27% from 1 January 2027

- Euro-area, EU single-market and Schengen membership, with free capital movement and around 100 bilateral tax treaties

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

The Netherlands in November 2026 is one of Europe's most open and productive economies, combining a world-class port and logistics system, a globally important high-tech cluster and a predictable tax environment. GDP grew 1.8% in 2025, and growth has accelerated in 2026: the economy expanded 0.6% quarter-on-quarter and 2.1% year-on-year in the third quarter, with manufacturing the largest contributor and exports of machinery and transport equipment rising. Foreign companies and investors invested €72 billion in the Netherlands in the first half of 2026, mainly from the United States and Germany, and the NFIA supported 180 foreign investment projects in 2025, 30% of them focused on R&D. Public finances are sound, with a 2025 deficit of 1.6% of GDP, and the minority cabinet led by Prime Minister Rob Jetten, sworn in on 23 February 2026, has set out a 2027 deficit target of 2.2% of GDP alongside higher defence spending.

The Netherlands' main structural challenge is physical capacity: electricity grid congestion, labour shortages and housing are limiting how fast new industrial and technology investment can be connected and staffed. Many industrial firms are on waiting lists for stronger grid connections, and inflation rose to 3.7% in October 2026, driven by energy prices. The response is substantial and well-funded. Project Beethoven commits €2.5 billion to the Eindhoven region for 33,000 additional technicians by 2030, transport, nearly 20,000 homes and grid upgrades; the first 32 km section of the national hydrogen network is operating in Rotterdam; and grid operators are expanding capacity. For investors, this creates opportunities in grid technology, battery storage, on-site generation, housing and technical training, while sites with available grid capacity command a premium.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Electricity grid congestion	Many regions have waiting lists for new or larger connections, and industrial users rank behind schools and hospitals in priority	Confirm grid capacity before choosing a site, consider on-site solar, wind and batteries, and engage early with regional grid operators
Minority government	The D66–VVD–CDA cabinet holds 66 of 150 seats, so budgets and reforms need opposition support	Policy fundamentals are stable and cross-party; track budget negotiations on tax, social security and the 2028 wealth-tax reform
Inflation and energy costs	Inflation reached 3.7% in October 2026, with energy prices up 14.4% year-on-year	ECB rate rises are working to contain inflation; build energy-price and wage scenarios into business plans and consider long-term power contracts
Labour and housing shortages	Shortages of technical staff and housing constrain expansion, especially in the Brainport region	Use the 30% ruling and the WBSO credit to attract and fund talent, and partner with universities on Project Beethoven training programmes
Economic-security screening	The government intervened in chipmaker Nexperia in 2025 under the Goods Availability Act, and sensitive technology investments face closer scrutiny	Plan for investment-screening and export-control reviews in semiconductors and critical technology; most sectors remain fully open
Changes to expatriate tax relief	The maximum 30% ruling allowance falls to 27% from 1 January 2027	Factor the change into remuneration packages; the regime remains among the most attractive in Europe

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

The Netherlands has a low-risk profile as a founding EU member, euro-area economy and FATF member with sound public finances and strong legal institutions. The 2025 deficit of 1.6% of GDP and a 2027 target of 2.2% leave the country well inside EU fiscal rules, and growth accelerated to 2.1% year-on-year in the third quarter of 2026. The main points to monitor are the parliamentary arithmetic of the minority cabinet, which holds 66 of 150 seats and must negotiate its budget with opposition parties, and the effect of higher energy prices on inflation,

which reached 3.7% in October 2026. Investors in semiconductors and other sensitive technologies should plan for national-security screening and export-control requirements, as the Nexperia case showed; these are a compliance consideration rather than a barrier for most sectors. Practical constraints such as grid congestion are best managed through early site due diligence.

MARKET ACCESS

As an EU member, the Netherlands gives investors tariff-free access to the EU single market and to all EU free trade agreements, with WTO membership and the EU common trade policy governing trade with third countries. Euro membership removes currency risk across the euro area, and Schengen membership allows passport-free movement. The Port of Rotterdam, Schiphol airport and dense road, rail and inland-waterway links along the Rhine make the country Europe's leading gateway for goods, with deep-sea container volumes to and from North America rising strongly in 2026. Germany and Belgium are its closest markets, and the planned extension of the hydrogen network to both countries reinforces the Netherlands' role as an energy hub for north-west Europe.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Prime Minister's Office (Prime Minister Rob Jetten)	Leads the D66–VVD–CDA minority cabinet sworn in on 23 February 2026 and sets the government's overall direction	Primary reference point for national priorities and major strategic projects
Netherlands Foreign Investment Agency (NFIA / Invest in Holland)	National investment promotion agency working with regional development agencies to support foreign investors	Standard first point of contact for site selection, incentives and introductions
De Nederlandsche Bank (DNB)	National central bank within the Eurosystem and banking supervisor; the ECB deposit rate has been 2.50% since September 2026	Relevant for banking, payments and financial-sector licensing
Ministry of Finance (Minister Eelco Heinen)	Leads the budget and tax policy, including the 2027 budget and planned wealth-tax reform	Key counterpart on tax rulings policy and public finances
Ministry of Economic Affairs (Minister Heleen Herbert)	Oversees industrial policy, the NFIA, the Netherlands Enterprise Agency and economic-security measures	Relevant for incentives, innovation funding and investment screening
Minister for Foreign Trade and Development (Sjoerd Sjoerdsma)	Responsible for trade promotion, export policy and development cooperation	Counterpart for trade missions and international partnerships
Port of Rotterdam Authority and Brainport Development	Lead development of the port's energy transition projects and the Eindhoven high-tech region respectively	Essential partners for logistics, energy and semiconductor investments

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The American Chamber of Commerce in the Netherlands, the Netherlands British Chamber of Commerce, the German-Dutch Chamber of Commerce and the employers' federation VNO-NCW are the main business associations, with regular dialogue with government on tax and regulation. The NFIA works with regional development agencies such as those covering Rotterdam, Amsterdam and Brainport Eindhoven to support new investors, and the Netherlands Enterprise Agency administers innovation, export and subsidy schemes. Invest-NL, the national promotional investment institution, and the European Investment Bank co-finance energy transition and innovation projects. Embassies of major partners maintain commercial sections that are a useful source of introductions.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

The Netherlands suits investors seeking a stable, well-connected European base: companies establishing European headquarters, distribution and logistics centres around Amsterdam, Schiphol and Rotterdam; semiconductor, photonics and high-tech firms joining the Brainport ecosystem and using the innovation box and WBSO credit; energy-transition investors in hydrogen, carbon capture, offshore wind, grid technology and storage;

and R&D-intensive life sciences and technology companies. Investors in sensitive technologies should plan for national-security screening.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the NFIA and regional development agencies
Open dialogue with Invest in Holland to compare locations, incentives and partners, and to arrange introductions to regional agencies.

STEP 2: Secure grid capacity and site certainty early
Verify electricity connection availability with grid operators before committing to a site, and plan for on-site generation or storage where needed.

STEP 3: Obtain tax certainty
Seek Advance Tax Rulings or Advance Pricing Agreements and assess eligibility for the innovation box, WBSO credit and the 30% ruling.

STEP 4: Plan talent and housing for staff
Partner with universities and Project Beethoven programmes, and factor the 2027 change to the 30% ruling into remuneration.

STEP 5: Review economic-security requirements
For semiconductors and critical technology, assess investment-screening and export-control obligations with specialist counsel at the outset.